

may feel judged by the question. It's the difference between "Why do you like shopping so much?" and "What is it about shopping that you most enjoy?" Do you see how they hit differently? One enlists automatic fight mode, and the other leads to "Hmm. Never thought about that, let me dig deeper!" When inquiring inquisitively, avoid the "why."

After we've answered some of these non-why questions, we **assess**. This is where we are now pairing information and facts with our thoughts and feelings and noticing any patterns that may exist. More questions at this stage can be helpful as we synthesize and begin to pull everything together.

What do the various data points mean?

What do I make of my feelings and my conscious or subconscious responses?

Are there any patterns of behavior or thoughts that I'm noticing?

What am I learning about myself?

How do I function best?

Now it's time to **respond**. At this stage we now have the opportunity for informed action, which is quite different from uninformed, unintentional reactivity. Given what we've learned about ourselves, we can utilize that knowledge in a way that is kind and provides space for next steps. This action feels different from "shoulding" and "musting" on ourselves. This step acknowledges the realities of circumstances, how you may have responded in the past, and gives room to trailblaze new paths where needed. Or it may lead you to continue on in the way you were going with more confidence!

And once we've done all that, we do it again! **Repeat** the process, because inevitably there will be an opportunity for these steps again today, tomorrow, and in the weeks/months/years to come! The good news is, this process becomes less and less cumbersome and time-consuming the more you do it and will eventually become second nature. As you implement these practices, you will notice that curiosity doesn't just lead to learning more about what you love, it also builds the skills of creativity, problem solving, research, and more. All skills that are essential to practicing values-based spending. You can even turn around and give the gift of curiosity to others by asking open-ended questions that aim at valuing and understanding.

Engaging in these steps of **creating space, observing objectively, inquiring inquisitively, assessing, and responding** will almost certainly